

Week 5 — Education Pathways: Picking Your Route

Goal: Choose, with evidence, how you'd actually get the education — because “go to school for engineering” hides at least four very different routes with very different costs, timelines, and lifestyles. Read `resources/education-pathways.md` first for the map; this week you fill in the local details.

Part 1: Research

Investigate all four routes **as they actually exist where you live**:

Route 1: Community college → transfer to a 4-year engineering program

- Which community college(s) near you have an engineering or pre-engineering track?
- Do they have a **transfer agreement (articulation agreement)** with your state university's engineering school? Find the actual agreement page.
- Cost per year, class schedule options (evening? online? — matters if you're working)

Route 2: Engineering Technology degree (AS or BS in MET/EET)

- What's the difference between *engineering* and *engineering technology*? (Look up both; ask r/AskEngineers)
- Who near you offers it, what does it cost, and what jobs does it lead to?

Route 3: Apprenticeship

- For EE-leaning: IBEW electrician apprenticeships (paid from day one, “earn while you learn”). Find your local IBEW chapter and their application requirements/timeline.
- For ME-leaning: machinist/toolmaker/industrial maintenance apprenticeships — check apprenticeship.gov for registered programs near you.
- What do apprentices earn in year 1 and at journeyman level in your area?

Route 4: Straight to a 4-year university

- In-state cost, admission requirements, and what the first two years actually look like (hint: the same calculus/physics you'd take at community college for a third of the price)

For each route, record: total cost, years to a credential, whether you can work while doing it, whether ABET accreditation applies (see the resources file for why you should care), and what door it opens at the end.

Part 2: Essay (700–1000 words)

Prompt: *“My education plan and why I chose it.”*

Requirements:

- Commit to a route (combinations count — e.g., “technician job + community college nights + transfer” is a route).
- Show your work: why this one over the other three? Use your cost and timeline numbers.
- Name the **first three concrete steps** and put a date on each (e.g., “meet with the community college advisor before ,” ***“IBEW application window opens ”***).
- Name the biggest risk to your plan and what you’d do if it happens.

Done when

- ☐ All four routes researched with local specifics
- ☐ Essay written with dated next steps
- ☐ Walkthrough conversation done